He reported how Indian flags and banners were nailed-up throughout East Berlin with slogans of friendship and photographs of Gandhi side-by-side with those of Honecker.

Her presence offered the East Germans an opportunity to promote stronger ties with Delhi and other non-aligned nations, and seek greater economic cooperation, especially in the area of coal mining. Already by this time the relationship between the First Secretary and Gandhi was better than cordial. The previous year, when India declared an emergency to control an 'internal disturbance', Gandhi thanked Honecker for his 'understanding and sympathy'.13 For Gandhi, the Berlin visit evoked many personal memories. 'Forty years ago, I came here with my mother,' she recounted. 'It was a time when dark clouds were gathering over Germany and its neighbours. We took a deep interest in this struggle between freedom and fascism. With growing dismay, we found that appeasement was mistaken for peace.' Honecker lapped up her laudations of friendship, and was positively beaming when she proclaimed the '[relationship] between [them] was an excellent example of cooperation between countries with different systems, which is a fact of contemporary international life'.

In gratitude, Gandhi received a 21-gun salute farewell. Dressed in a longsleeved yellow silk dress, she used her departure to extend an invitation to Honecker to pay an official visit to India. It was a crowning moment for the SED's well-oiled diplomatic machine. 'It will be interesting to see if he stays as far away from the subject of Indo-Pakistan relations as Mrs Gandhi did from East-West German matters,' the US Ambassador in East Berlin, John Sherman Cooper, acidly noted. He also pointedly observed that none of the 'numerous photos' published during Gandhi's visit connected her in any way with the Berlin Wall.

Honecker's status as the darling of the Helsinki process was never going to last for long. By the mid-1970s, the issue of prominent critics came into sharp focus when singer Wolf Biermann was stripped of his citizenship while touring in West Germany, accused of 'speaking against' the GDR during a concert in Cologne. The action left Biermann unable to return to his wife and child in East Berlin. Predictably, however, as his supporters in the West decried the 'inhumane lunacy' of the action, more and more of the